

Describe a special hotel you stayed in

You should say:

- Where it was
- What it was like
- Why you went there
- And explain how you felt about it

I needed to rack my brains* to think of a hotel to talk about because I haven't been on holiday for ages** for various reasons, but mainly because of the pandemic. It feels like forever! Anyway, in the dim and distant past***, I was fortunate enough**** to stay in a truly impressive guesthouse so I've decided to talk about that one.

*to rack your brains = to think hard

**for ages = for a long time

***the dim and distant past = a very long time ago

****to be fortunate enough = to be lucky

****guesthouse = a small hotel; a B&B

A few years back, I was travelling around Europe and I hadn't pre-booked* hotels because I wanted an adventure and I wasn't sure how long I wanted to stay in each place. I had finished my degree a few weeks before and I just needed a change of scene** and a break before I started work. I'd been saving for a few years because I wanted to see as much as possible and have the holiday of a lifetime. One night, I

*pre-booked = to book in advance

**a change of scene = time spent in a different place

was in Paris, but like I said I had nothing reserved*** so I went to the tourist

***to reserve = to book

information centre and they recommended this particular hotel to me.



Some hotels are **exceptional*** because they are **five star** or they are full of **facilities** such as **an Olympic-sized swimming pool**, but this hotel was special for **a host of**** other reasons. **It was located in the heart of Paris** so the **location** was **spot on*****. It wasn't **a chain hotel******, but that was what made it **unique**. In **chain hotels**, they are very **samey******* and the food tends to be a bit **iffy*******.

***exceptional =**
amazing; special

****a host of = a**
large number of

*****spot on = just right;**
perfect

******a chain hotel = a group**
of hotels

*******samey = very**
similar

*******iffy = not very**
good

This hotel was **a boutique hotel*** with **the human touch****. All the food was **homemade** and **to the highest quality**. The **continental breakfast** was so **moreish***** that I decided to stay a few extra nights. It was **relatively pricey****** compared to other hotels I used, **mind you**, **it was worth it**. You need to **treat yourself******* every now and again.

***a boutique hotel = small**
and usually trendy

****the human touch =**
friendly and personal

*****moreish =**
you want more

******pricey =**
expensive

*******to treat yourself = to spend money on something you'll enjoy**



Fluency and Coherence - Organisation

Grammatical Range and Accuracy - Grammar

Lexical Resource - Vocabulary

Describe a place that you remember that is full of colours

You should say:

- Where it is
- What it is like
- What it is used for
- And explain why you remember it

I was struggling to think of a place to talk about because colour is not something I pay much attention to, to be perfectly honest, but if I remember rightly, my primary school was quite a colourful place full of bright, vivid splashes of colour so I've decided to talk about that place.

I can remember my classroom quite clearly/vividly and there was an explosion of colour. The walls were painted pale blue – I think I heard recently that this colour has a calming effect on the body so this is probably why it is used in schools. Red is not a good colour to use because it is regarded as an angry and aggressive colour and can get you too excited and it would not be good to have a class full of overenergized and hyper kids!

All the chairs and tables were different colours and we used to fight over who could sit on which chair because everyone wanted to sit in their favourite colour. Mine was blue, I always tried to get the blue chair.

Interestingly, the walls were a pastel colour, whereas the other objects in the room were strong colours. You'd think that pastels would be better to not overstimulate the pupils; however, I guess schools tend to use bright colours to make them look like fun places to learn.

Youngsters are attracted to bright colours.

The main reason why I remember it so well is that I spent the first seven years of my life in that school and it left a lasting impression on me because I was probably the happiest when I was in primary school. Secondary school/high school was a depressing, miserable place and all we did was prepare for exams and I remember it as a much darker place lacking in colour

PART 3

Is colour important for clothing?

My initial reaction was no, it doesn't matter what colour clothing is...

But if you think about clothing for specific purposes, then it is **vitaly important**.

For example, some need to wear **hi-vis clothing** for their jobs...

The police are a **prime example of this**. They need to wear **reflective clothing** if they are attending an accident, for example.



This is a hi-vis vest

Describe a crowded place you have been to

You should say:

- Where it was
- When you went there
- Who you went there with and why
- And explain how you felt about it

It was quite tricky to decide what to talk about because I can't remember the last time I was in a particularly crowded place apart from when I am commuting to work and talking about that would be a bit tedious so nothing immediately came to mind but then I suddenly remembered being in a crowd a while ago so I've decided to talk about that particular experience.

I can't remember precisely when it was because I have a terrible memory for dates, but it was a few years back and I was travelling around the UK. That particular day, I was visiting London and meeting one of my friends. The weather was perfect, there had been a heatwave the previous week, but it had cooled down to a much more pleasant temperature with not a cloud in the sky. Because it was summer, the city was jampacked with* tourists... I guess it is all year round because it is a bustling city, but it was teeming with* sightseers that day.

*jampacked with; *teeming with = full of

We decided to go to Covent Garden for lunch, which is located in the west of London. It is a vibrant place which is a must-see destination for anyone who enjoys shopping, theatre, culture etc. It was my first time there, but I found it a bit overwhelming* because it was heaving with people**. I kept panicking because I didn't want to lose my friend. I felt like a fish out of water***, to be perfectly honest.

Luckily, we found a café with outdoor seating and then I was able to calm down and relax a bit. I don't have a phobia about crowds, but I think it was just because I was in unfamiliar surroundings and I started to get a bit anxious. Don't get me wrong, I didn't have a panic attack****, I was just a bit overwhelmed*. I think I would struggle to live and work in such a crowded place day in day out, but I suppose you get used to it if you are experiencing it on a daily basis.

*overwhelming/overwhelmed = have a strong emotional effect on

**to be heaving with people = to be full of people

***to feel like a fish out of water = If you feel like a fish out of water, you do not feel comfortable or relaxed because you are in an unusual or unfamiliar situation

****to have a panic attack = People experiencing a panic attack may believe they are having a heart attack or they are dying or going crazy.

Describe a place in your hometown that you like to go to with friends or family

You should say:

- Where it is
- How you know about the place
- What you do there
- And explain why you like to go there

The first place that came to mind when I read this topic card was a cinema that I frequent regularly. It is located on the outskirts of the city in an up-and-coming area. There is a new residential area and a number of entertainment places have been built such as a bowling alley, an ice skating rink and this cinema.

As it is situated out of town, transport is a must. There are a number of alternatives such as going there by car or there is a regular bus service. Personally, I prefer to go there by car, as it is more convenient because you don't need to worry about bus timetables or when the last bus is. Fortunately, there are plenty of parking spaces and if you are using the facilities, then you get the price of the parking ticket refunded.

When this place opened, they did loads of advertising **such as** on the sides of buses and **billboards** in the city centre so that is when I first heard about it. They also had a special offer of **buy one get one free** for the first few weeks after they opened so I went with a few of **my mates**. We were so **overwhelmed** by **the whole cinematic experience** that we are now **regulars**.

What makes this cinema better than the one in town is that it has **an IMAX screen**. **From memory**, IMAX means Image Maximum and is much larger than a normal cinema screen. **The audio** is **astonishing** too so it makes movies much more exciting and **enthralling** to watch. If you've never seen a film on IMAX, **I'd thoroughly recommend it**. It's an **eye-opening** and **spine-tingling** experience.

Describe a polluted place you know/you have visited that has been affected by pollution

You should say:

- Where it is
- What type of pollution it is
- What are the causes of the pollution
- And explain how this pollution can be controlled

Sadly, the world **is getting increasingly more** polluted **year on year** so there are loads of places I could talk about and **numerous** different kinds of pollution such as **water, noise, light pollution and so on**, but **I've decided to talk about** air pollution in London.

It's one of the world's **leading** risk factors for death and **it is attributed/linked to roughly** 5 million deaths each year. **I'm pretty sure that** air pollution **is responsible for** 9% of deaths **globally**. It is caused **directly** through our use of electricity, fuels, and transportation and **indirectly**, when we buy goods and services that use energy in their production and delivery. Most of this air pollution results from the burning of **fossil fuels**, such as coal, oil, natural gas, and **gasoline** to produce electricity and **power** our **vehicles**.

The majority of the air pollution in London is caused by vehicles – cars, buses, lorries and suchlike. Because it is a densely populated city and commuters are travelling to and from work each day, traffic congestion and traffic jams are the norm and if drivers sit in traffic without turning off their car engines, then high levels of nitrogen dioxide are emitted. Apparently, exhaust fumes are twice as deadly as roads.

What can be done to combat this problem? Well, there are a variety of solutions such as banning vehicles, introducing taxes for drivers etc, but this does not really solve the issue because at the end of the day*, workers still need to get to work. When I was living in Australia, a few years back, they had free electric buses on work days. This was an incentive to leave your car at home because they were free and you don't have the hassle of trying to find a parking space. This is a good initiative** and should be implemented by more towns and cities.

*at the end of the day = something that you say before you give the most important fact of a situation; taking everything into consideration

**an initiative = an act, plan or strategy intended to resolve a difficulty or improve a situation; a fresh approach to something

Describe a country or city that you would like to live or work in the future

You should say:

- Where the country or city is
- Why you would like to live or work there
- Who you would like to live or work with
- Why you would like it

If I was given the opportunity to live anywhere in the world, I would choose Italy. There are a number of key factors in my decision. Firstly, the food... I am a massive fan of Italian cuisine and, as a vegetarian, I would be able to find plenty to eat. Pizza, pasta and risotto are my favourite dishes and I could easily live on them. I would probably be clinically obese after a couple of months, though.

A further major reason is that I would love to speak Italian fluently. I can already get by in the language; however, I'd love to be able to speak like a native. It is an incredibly beautiful and melodic language and if I was living there, I'm sure I could pick it up fairly quickly.

Although I can think of millions of reasons why I'd love to relocate there, one of the main ones is that I am captivated by Italian art. For example, in Rome there is the Sistine Chapel, which is covered in frescoes. It is my dream to see this masterpiece.

Oh, I don't think I have mentioned the weather... well, I come from a country with a relatively cold climate and, therefore, I would relish the opportunity to live in a warmer country. I am a sun worshipper and sadly, I do not get the chance to sunbathe and chill out in the sun.

So, as you can see, there are a number of reasons why Italy would be my chosen destination. I'm not entirely sure what I would do in terms of work, but I can worry about that later! I'm hoping that I don't have to work, I would love to have the time to write a novel, as it has long been my dream to become a published author.

My spouse and kids are also lovers of all things Italian so I'm pretty sure that I would have no trouble persuading them to move there with me as well.

Describe a beautiful city you know

You should say:

- Where it is
- How you know about it
- What it is famous for
- And explain why you think it is a beautiful city

I have decided to talk about a city that I only know through the media, as to date* I have not been lucky enough to visit it and this city is London. London is the capital city of the UK and is located in the south of the country. Off the top of my head, it has just under ten million inhabitants and is teeming with visitors and holidaymakers.

To date = up until this point in time – this is useful for IELTS Writing Task 1 General as well e.g. *I am writing to complain about... I spoke to the manager at the time and he said he would call me; however, to date I have heard nothing.*

London has a long history and this can be seen in its buildings such as the Houses of Parliament and iconic buildings such as Big Ben and Buckingham Palace where the Queen of England resides. These buildings give the place a historical feel and I imagine that it is like being in a Harry Potter book when you are walking around. The impression I have is that London is picturesque because it has a perfect blend of modern and traditional architecture. I like this contrast between the old and new – Paris has this as well, but it does not blend it well like London – it is separated into historical and contemporary.

In addition to its buildings, London is an unusual city because it is filled with public parks such as Hyde Park. These are huge open spaces filled with trees, flowers and wildlife. For the residents of London, who have very little outdoor space, these are not only attractive places, but also great for getting some fresh air or walking your dog. For those visiting the city, I imagine these are great places to visit and have a picnic if it isn't raining – I've heard it rains a lot in England though.

Another thing that I've heard about London is that it is a multicultural city and this makes it a colourful place, as you have places such as Chinatown where there are a large number of Chinese restaurants. As a football fan, if I were to visit London, I would go to the football stadiums such as the Emirates Stadium, which is home to the Arsenal football team and from the pictures I've seen it's a stunningly beautiful stadium.

PART 3

Tourists – positive or negative

Overwhelmingly positive, as many places could not survive without tourism.

They generate income for the country and provide many jobs in sectors such as the service industry.

Damage to the landscape: litter, vandalism, traffic congestion and pollution etc. Local goods can become expensive because tourists will pay more.

PART 3

Why do people like visiting historical places?

Some are genuinely interested in history so it is both for enjoyment and educational purposes.

If you are interested in a particular place, Japan, for example, then visiting its historical places of interest can give you a better understanding of the culture and people.

Nowadays, there are a lot of visitors who visit historical places because they are instagrammable/instaworthy – they put images on social media to show off.

Describe your dream home

You should say:

- Where it would be
- What it would be like
- Why you would like it
- And explain what you will do to get it

I'm so pleased I've got this topic because I'm fascinated by architecture and houses. If I had a dream house, it would be located near Lake Garda in northern Italy. This is one of my favourite places in the world because of the cuisine, climate and beautiful scenery.

In terms of size, I wouldn't want a massive house, but just big enough to accommodate me and my family and a few guests. Obviously, it would have a swimming pool. Ideally, I'd love an infinity pool. That is a pool that looks like it is falling off the edge and is merging with the sky. I would love a view of the stunningly beautiful lake from the property so I could sit out on the patio and look at the water. I find looking at water incredibly relaxing so this patio with tables, chairs and sun beds would be a place where I could chill out.

In addition, there would be a lawn with lots of mature trees. I'm not green-fingered so I wouldn't want lots of flowers, a low-maintenance garden would be perfect. I would like the outdoor space to be filled with lights so that at night we could use it for entertaining. Oh, yes, I nearly forgot, it absolutely must have a pizza oven. I would love to be able to make my own pizzas and serve them to my guests.

Finally, I would like the house to have a homely feel. That means that everyone who visits feels at home because it would be welcoming and comfortable. To be honest, I don't know how I'm going to get it, I think the only way is to marry a millionaire!